

Student Activity Book

Grades 3-5 • Ages 8-10

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

STUDENT COPY

1

hackles up!



Hackle

whose quills stand up when something feels off

2



Latch

LOCK IT

3



Peeper

SPOT IT

4



Pip

SHARE SMART

5



Buddy

SAFE PEOPLE

6



Ember

KIND AND WELL

7



Fixit

FIX IT

PLATE I. The Hackles crew, drawn from life: Hackle (1) and the six friends who look after each strand.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Hands-On Hackers (the good kind) (ages 8-10)

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Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell

Name: _____ Class: _____

Field note

No. 1

Welcome, Hands-On Hacker! A hacker is a clever puzzle solver. The GOOD kind of hacker uses brain power to keep people safe.

Hackles are what rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. That uh-oh feeling is a gut check, and it is a good one to listen to. A false alarm is fine. Nobody is ever mad about a false alarm.

Your super-moves: HACKLES UP? (notice the feeling), then PAUSE. CHECK. TELL.

You are never in trouble for telling. It is never your fault.

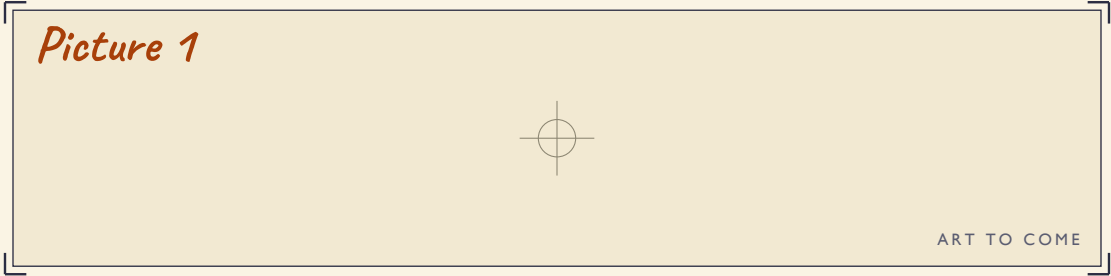
[Illustration: the squad (Mateo, Amara, Priya, Kenji, Sam) and Hackle (a baby hedgehog with soft pale-yellow, tangerine-tipped quills that stand up when something is off) waving from a clubhouse door.]

Meet the squad: Mateo (puzzle lover), Amara (game builder), Priya (question-asker), Kenji (kind and quick to tell), Sam (artist), and Hackle (a cartoon baby hedgehog, not a real chatbot, whose quills stand up at an uh-oh feeling).

Page 1: My Trusted Hand

Write or draw one trusted adult on each finger. At least one should be at school and one at home.

FINGER	MY TRUSTED PERSON
Thumb	
Pointer	
Middle	
Ring	
Pinky	



a large outline of a hand with a space on each finger.

My first sentence is (circle one or write your own):

- "I need help with something online."
- "Something happened and I'm not sure what to do."
- "I'm not in trouble. I just need to tell you something."

Page 2: Exit Ticket

Write one grown-up you can tell: _____

The first sentence I would say:





Page 3: Comic and Puzzle

COMIC: KENJI CLIMBS THE LADDER

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Kenji at a tablet; a pop-up says "FREE COINS! Click now!"]* Kenji: "Hmm. My tummy says wait."

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Kenji holds up a flat palm; Hackle appears.]* Hackle: "Pause!"

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Kenji with a magnifying glass looking at the pop-up.]* Kenji: "It's rushing me and offering free stuff. That's a trick."

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Kenji walks to Aunt Lin in the kitchen.]* Kenji: "I need help with something online."

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Aunt Lin kneeling and smiling.]* Aunt Lin: "Thank you for telling me. You did exactly the right thing."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Kenji and Aunt Lin high-five; Hackle gives a thumbs-up.]* Hackle: "Telling is a super-power."

PUZZLE: UNSCRAMBLE THE LADDER WORDS

SCRAMBLED	YOUR ANSWER
TLEL	
RDEIFN	
DLDAER	
TROPER	
PUASE	
KCEHC	

Bonus: Write the three rungs of the Ladder in order, from bottom to top.

Level-Up Challenge: Write what you would say if a friend told YOU something scary. Then teach the Ladder to a younger buddy in one minute.

Page 4: Crack-Timer Worksheet

Our pretend Guess-Machine makes 1,000 guesses every second. Each new word makes the lock 36 TIMES bigger.

Part 1: Fill in the table

LOCK	HOW MANY POSSIBLE LOCKS?	TIME FOR THE GUESS-MACHINE
1 digit PIN	10	less than 1 second
2 digit PIN	100	
4 digit PIN	10,000	
2 words	1,296	about 1 second
3 words	46,656	
4 words	___ x 36 = _____	
5 words		about 17 hours

Part 2: Roll your PRACTICE passphrase

Roll two dice. First die = row. Second die = column. Find the word on the Word List. Write it here.

ROLL 1	ROLL 2	ROLL 3
Row ___ Column ___	Row ___ Column ___	Row ___ Column ___
Word:	Word:	Word:

My practice passphrase: _____

Remember: This is only for practice. Never use it for a real account.
Never share a real passphrase with anyone except your grown-up.

Part 3: Do the math

How many possible 3-word passphrases from our 36-word list?

About how long would the Guess-Machine need? -----

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Lab Extension: Human Crack Race (record your guesses)

SECRET NUMBER	GUESSES NEEDED
1 digit	
2 digits	
3 digits (30 seconds)	

Page 5: Exit Ticket

Which is harder to guess: a 3-word dice passphrase, or the word "Dragon1"? Circle one:

3-word dice passphrase Dragon1

Why? _____

Page 6: Comic - Mateo's Clubhouse Lock

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Mateo at a clubhouse door with a one-digit number lock.]* Mateo: "Nobody will guess my lock!"

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Priya tries 0, 1, 2, 3 and the door pops open.]* Priya: "Ten tries. Easy!"

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Mateo adds more number dials.]* Mateo: "I'll add more numbers!"

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Sam holds up three dice.]* Sam: "Why not roll dice for three random words? Dice cannot be guessed!"

Panel 5: *[Illustration: A long lock with word cards: kite, tunnel, orbit.]* Mateo: "kite tunnel orbit. Long and random!"

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Mateo whispering to Abuela.]* Mateo: "Only Abuela and I know it."

Page 7: Puzzle - Password Doctor

For each pair, circle the STRONGER one. Then write why in a few words.

PAIR	WHICH IS STRONGER?	WHY
A: "Max2015" or "kettle river orbit"		
B: "P@ssw0rd!" or "lantern zebra quilt candle"		
C: "my dog's name" or "walnut igloo tunnel"		
D: a 4 digit PIN or a 4 word passphrase		

True or false? (Circle one)

1. A password is safe to share with a best friend. TRUE FALSE
2. Adding a number to a short word makes it very strong. TRUE FALSE
3. Rolling dice for words is stronger than choosing favorites. TRUE FALSE

Challenge: Each word makes the lock 36 times bigger. How many possible locks for 3 words? _____

Level-Up Challenge: Beat the Machine! How many possible locks for an 8-word passphrase from our 36-word list? (Hint: 36 to the 8th. Use a calculator.) About how many years would our pretend Guess-Machine need?

Scam Spotters

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Page 8: Scam Sort Recording Sheet

SPOT = Secrets asked, Pressure, Offer too good, Trick to move you.

My group's results (write the card numbers):

SCAM PILE	REAL PILE	PAUSE-AND-ASK PILE

Our group matched _____ out of _____ cards (18 for a half-deck, 36 for the full deck) with the answer key.

The trickiest card was number _____ because

Draw a hand sign for each SPOT letter:

S	P	O	T

Page 9: Exit Ticket

Circle the SPOT sign you will watch for and write one sentence:

S P O T

My Spotter reply: "No thanks. _____."

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Page 10: Comic - Priya the Scam Spotter

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Priya at a game; a flashing banner says "WINNER! 10,000 FREE COINS! Click in 10 minutes!"]* Priya: "Whoa!"

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Priya holds up a flat palm.]* Hackle: "Pause!"

Panel 3: *[Illustration: SPOT letters float above the banner: P, O, T.]* Priya: "Pressure. Offer too good. Trick to click. Three signs!"

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Priya shows her mom the screen.]* Priya: "Mom, can you check this with me?"

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Mom opening the official game store on her own.]* Mom: "No free coins here. Good spotting."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Priya types "No thanks. I'm checking with my grown-up." in the chat.]* Hackle: "Spotter power!"

PUZZLE: SPOT MATCH

Draw a line (or write the letter) to match each message to its SPOT sign.

MESSAGE	S P O O R T?
"Reply with your password to keep your account."	
"Only 5 minutes left!"	
"You won a free tablet!"	
"Click this link or move to another app."	

Level-Up Challenge: Write the silliest scam you can think of (like "FREE DRAGON! Send me your lunch!") and mark its SPOT signs.

Secret Code Lab

Page 11: Decoder Sheet

Vocabulary: Encrypt = scramble. Decrypt = unscramble. Key = the secret that unlocks it.

Use your cipher wheel (key 3 means turn the inner ring so inner D sits under outer A).

CODE	KEY	YOUR DECODED MESSAGE
SDXVH FKHFN WHOO	3	
YJQQ F YWZXYJI LWTBSZU	5	

Make your own: Write a short safety message here:

Pick a key (1 to 25): ____ Write your coded message here:

Give the scrambled message (but NOT the key) to a partner. Did they crack it? Yes / No How many tries? ____

Page 12: Exit Ticket

Decode this: ULCLY ZOHYL FVBY WHZZDVYK (key 7)

A KEY is: -----

Page 13: Comic and Puzzle

COMIC: THE SECRET NOTE

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Mateo writes a note, looking worried that it might be picked up.]* Mateo: "What if someone reads my note?"

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Mateo turns a paper cipher wheel.]* Mateo: "I'll scramble it with a key!"

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Amara reading the scrambled note: SDXVH FKHFN WHOO.]* Amara: "It looks like nonsense..."

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Mateo whispers the number 3 to Amara.]* Mateo: "The key is 3. Only you and I know."

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Amara using her wheel and smiling.]* Amara: "PAUSE CHECK TELL!"

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Hackle holding a giant key.]* Hackle: "A code is only as strong as its key. Keep keys secret!"

PUZZLE: CODE BREAKER BONUS

Decode each message. Use the key given.

CODE	KEY	MESSAGE
VGNN UQOGQPG	2	
QKKV QKEY YKIXKZ	6	
BTL GJSTU	1	

Mixed-alphabet bonus (use the key in the Reproducibles): DTTZ QZ ZIT
GSR SOWKQKN RGGK

Think: Why is a bigger set of keys harder to crack?

Level-Up Challenge: Make your own scrambled alphabet (a mixed-alphabet key). Write a safety message in code for a younger class, and plan how to give them the key safely (never in the same note!).

Data Detective

Page 14: Detective Dossier

Sort the 18 profile cards into three piles (one for each fake kid), then fill in a dossier for each. These kids are made up!

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	KID 1	KID 2	KID 3
First and last name			
Age			
School			
Where do they live?			
When and where could you find them?			
What could be a password guess?			
Which cards gave you the clues?			

How many clues did you have to put together to find a home? _____

Page 15: Exit Ticket

One thing that is safe to share: _____

One thing that should stay private: _____

My Clue Check question: "Could someone put these clues together to
_____?"

Page 16: Comic and Puzzle

COMIC: SAM'S CLUE CHECK

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Sam holds up a drawing of their grandmother's garden and a phone.]* Sam: "I want to post my picture!"

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Hackle zooms in on the picture: the house number and street sign are visible.]* Hackle: "Detective time!"

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Sam with a magnifying glass finds the clues.]* Sam: "Oh! You can see our house number and street."

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Sam crops the picture.]* Sam: "I'll crop it so only the flowers show."

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Sam and Grandma Whitfeather checking settings.]* Grandma: "Good Clue Check. Let's choose who can see it."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Hackle gives a thumbs up.]* Hackle: "Clues add up. Choose carefully."

PUZZLE: ODD ONE OUT

Cross out the one that does NOT belong in each row (it does not give away where you are or when you are alone).

ROW	CHOICES
1	street sign / house number / favorite color / school jersey
2	"Home alone until 6!" / "Love ice cream!" / team bus time / my after-school address
3	pet's name as a password hint / a joke / a picture of my front door / my full birthday and school

Level-Up Challenge: With a grown-up, look at your backpack, jersey or a family photo. What clues could a stranger see? Make one fix together (crop it, cover it, or skip it).

Game Chat Red Flags

Page 17: Red Flag Reporter

Draw a line from each message to its red flag.

MESSAGE	RED FLAG (WRITE THE NAME)
"Let's talk on another app, it's private."	
"Don't tell your parents."	
"I gave you coins, now you owe me."	
"If you were a real friend, you would..."	
"Where do you live? Who is home?"	
"Send me a picture of yourself."	

Red flags to choose from: Switch apps, Secrets, Gifts, Pressure or guilt, Personal questions, Pictures or camera.

Write the exit script: _____

Then BLOCK. _____ . _____

Page 18: Exit Ticket

The exit script is: "_____."

The grown-up I will tell is: _____

Page 19: Comic - Amara Says Bye

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Amara building a game world; a chat bubble from a player named "BlockMaster" says "You're so good!"]* Amara: "Thanks!"

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Chat bubble: "Let's talk on another app, just us. Don't tell your dad."]* Amara: "Hmm."

Panel 3: *[Illustration: A big red flag waving over the chat.]* Hackle: "Red flag! Two of them: switch apps and secrets."

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Amara types: "Not doing that. Bye."]* Amara: "Not doing that. Bye."

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Amara taps Block and Report.]* Amara: "Block. Report."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Amara and her dad.]* Amara: "Dad, I need to tell you something." Dad: "Thank you for telling me. You did exactly the right thing."

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GREEN OR RED? COLOR THE FLAG.

MESSAGE	COLOR GREEN OR RED
"Good game! Want another round?"	
"Don't tell your mom we talk."	
"Can you help me with this level?"	
"Let's switch to a private app."	

Level-Up Challenge: Write the exit script in your own words ("Nope. Bye.") and list three things a good gaming buddy does (green flags).

Upstander Moves

Page 20: Four Moves Planner

MOVE	WHAT I COULD SAY OR DO IN THIS SITUATION: A CLASSMATE WAS LEFT OUT OF A GROUP CHAT ON PURPOSE.
Say It	
Stand With	
Keep It (don't pass it)	
Tell It	

Safe-first rule: If I do not feel safe, I skip Say It and use Stand With, Keep It and Tell It.

Page 21: Exit Ticket

The move I would try first is: _____

What I would say: _____

Page 22: Comic - Kenji Stands With

Panel 1: *[Illustration: A group chat on a screen, with a mean joke about Sam and laughing faces.]* Kids: "Ha ha ha."

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Kenji frowns and holds his phone away.]* Kenji: "That's not funny."

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Kenji sends Sam a private message: "That was mean. Sorry. Want to play at recess?"]*

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Kenji talks with Coach Dee.]* Kenji: "I need help. Someone is being mean in a chat."

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Sam smiles at recess with Kenji.]* Sam: "Thanks, Kenji."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Hackle holds four signs: Say It, Stand With, Keep It, Tell It.]*

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MATCH THE MOVE

SITUATION	WHICH MOVE?
You send a kind message to the person who was teased.	
You choose not to forward a mean picture.	
You tell your teacher about a mean chat.	
You say "That's not cool" calmly.	

Level-Up Challenge: Upstander Streak! This week, do one Stand With move (invite someone to play or sit with you). Write one line about how it went.

Real or Fake?

Page 23: Detective Notes

The 3 S's: Source (who made it?), Sense (does it make sense or rush me?),
Second look (can I check another way?).

CARD	REAL, FAKE OR CAN'T TELL?	WHICH S HELPED?
Picture 1		
Picture 2		
Voice 1		
Voice 2		
Chat 1		
Chat 2		

A chatbot is a _____, not a _____.

Page 24: Exit Ticket

One of the 3 S's is _____.

A question I can ask is: " _____?"

If I can't tell, I say: " _____."

Page 25: Comic - Grandma Pauses

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Priya's grandma on the phone; a voice says "I'm in trouble! Send gift cards! Don't tell anyone!"]*

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Grandma remembers Priya's hand sign: Pause.]*
Grandma: "Pause."

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Grandma hangs up.]* Grandma: "I will call back on the number I know."

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Grandma calls the real cousin, who answers happily from home.]*

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Priya and Grandma hug.]* Priya: "Computers can copy voices. Pause. Check. Tell."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Hackle holds a sign: "I can't tell. I'm asking a grown-up."]*

CHATBOT QUICK CHECK

Circle TRUE or FALSE.

1. A chatbot is a computer program. TRUE FALSE
2. A chatbot can be wrong. TRUE FALSE
3. A chatbot is a better friend than my family. TRUE FALSE
4. I should tell a grown-up if a chatbot says something scary or asks for secrets. TRUE FALSE

Level-Up Challenge: Write three kid-friendly facts about chatbots for a younger class (it is a program, it can be wrong, don't tell it secrets).

Family Code Word

Page 26: Practice Plan

My PRACTICE code word (for class only; not my real family word!):

The two parts of the plan:

1. CODE WORD: -----
2. CALLBACK: "I'll call you back on the number I know."

Which would make a good family code word? Circle the good ones.

OPTION	GOOD OR NOT?
my dog's name	
a silly three-word phrase nobody would guess	
my birthday	
a word you post online	
an unusual word the family agrees on	
my favorite team	

Reminder: The real word is decided at home and never shared outside the family. Do NOT write it here.

Page 27: Exit Ticket

If someone says "it's an emergency, don't tell anyone," I will

-----.

Page 28: Comic - Priya's Family Plan

Panel 1: *[Illustration: Priya's family at the kitchen table with a dice and a pad of paper.]* Priya: "Let's make a plan."

Panel 2: *[Illustration: They whisper and write nothing down.]* Mom: "Nobody tells it to anyone."

Panel 3: *[Illustration: A phone rings. Caller says "It's your uncle! Send me a gift card number right now!"]*

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Priya remains calm.]* Priya: "What's our code word?"

Panel 5: *[Illustration: The caller stumbles.]* Caller: "Um... I forgot."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Priya hangs up and calls her mom.]* Priya: "I'll call you back on the number I know."

PUZZLE: CALLBACK ORDER

Number the steps in order (1 to 4):

STEP	ORDER
Hang up and call back on a number I know	
Ask for the code word	
Tell a grown-up	
Don't send money, gift cards or passwords	

Level-Up Challenge: Real plan, real home! With a grown-up, make your real code word and callback plan, practice it once, and make a pick-up list. Never write the code word on anything you hand in.

Page 29: My OOPS Card

Fill in the missing words.

LETTER	STEP	IN MY WORDS
O	Oh, I'm ____	
O	____ and out	
P	____ (tell a trusted adult)	
S	____ it (with a grown-up)	

My first sentence to a grown-up: "_____."

Page 30: Exit Ticket

Write the four OOPS steps in your own words.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Page 31: Comic - Mateo's Oops

Panel 1: *[Illustration: A tablet shows "VIRUS! Call this number NOW!"]*
Mateo: "Oh no!"

Panel 2: *[Illustration: Mateo taps the pop-up. A page asks for a password.]*
Mateo: "Wait..."

Panel 3: *[Illustration: Mateo breathes slowly; Hackle hovers with the OOPS card.]* Hackle: "O: Oh, I'm okay."

Panel 4: *[Illustration: Mateo closes the page.]* Mateo: "O: off and out."

Panel 5: *[Illustration: Mateo goes to the kitchen to find Abuela.]* Mateo: "I made an oops and I need help."

Panel 6: *[Illustration: Abuela hugs him; they change a password together.]*
Abuela: "Gracias for telling me, mijo. Let's fix it together."

PUZZLE: OOPS OR NOT?

Write "Tell" or "OK" next to each.

SITUATION	TELL OR OK
I clicked a strange link	
I played a game with my cousin	
A pop-up told me to call a number	
I shared my password with a friend	

Level-Up Challenge: Teach your favorite lab move to a younger buddy in 60 seconds. Which Ladder rung is "People"? (Check Lesson 1!)

Page 32: Hands-On Hacker Certificate

Field note

No. 2

HANDS-ON HACKER CERTIFICATE (the good kind)

This certifies that _____

can notice when their hackles go up, and can PAUSE, CHECK and TELL!

They have:

- Listened to their hackles (the uh-oh gut check)
- Built a long, random passphrase
- Spotted scams with SPOT
- Made and cracked secret codes
- Done a Clue Check
- Said "Not doing that. Bye." to red flags
- Used the Four Moves to help others
- Checked if things are real or fake
- Made a family code word plan
- Used OOPS Recovery

And they know: telling is a super-power. False alarms are fine. It is never your fault.

Trust your hackles. · Hackles: a free kit · quillsup.org

Signed: _____ (teacher) Date: _____

[Illustration: Hackle with a gold star and the five squad members cheering.]

Field note

No. 3

Answer key: see separate Teacher Answer Key file.